

to sift through, and his face is splashed on billboards across metros for *Glory*. Back home, his rise has proven that talent and perseverance pay off. "I wouldn't have had a name there if not for this lucrative creative spell," he says. "They are surprised but I am seen as a *misaal* (role model) too."

This newfound fame has also infused a sense of confidence. "I am enjoying myself," he says of the recognition coming his way. "But I don't want to exhaust myself. Acting is an all-encompassing job. When I am in character, I don't like talking too much." The approach has clicked, with Vicky becoming the go-to actor for playing dads with emotional baggage and shades of grey. Father or villain, he's game for a challenge. Says Vicky, "I believe you get to know your *aukaat* (standing) as an actor only by working with multiple directors." Luckily for him, most hold him in high esteem. ■

—Suhani Singh

CINEMA ▼

The Talent Hunter

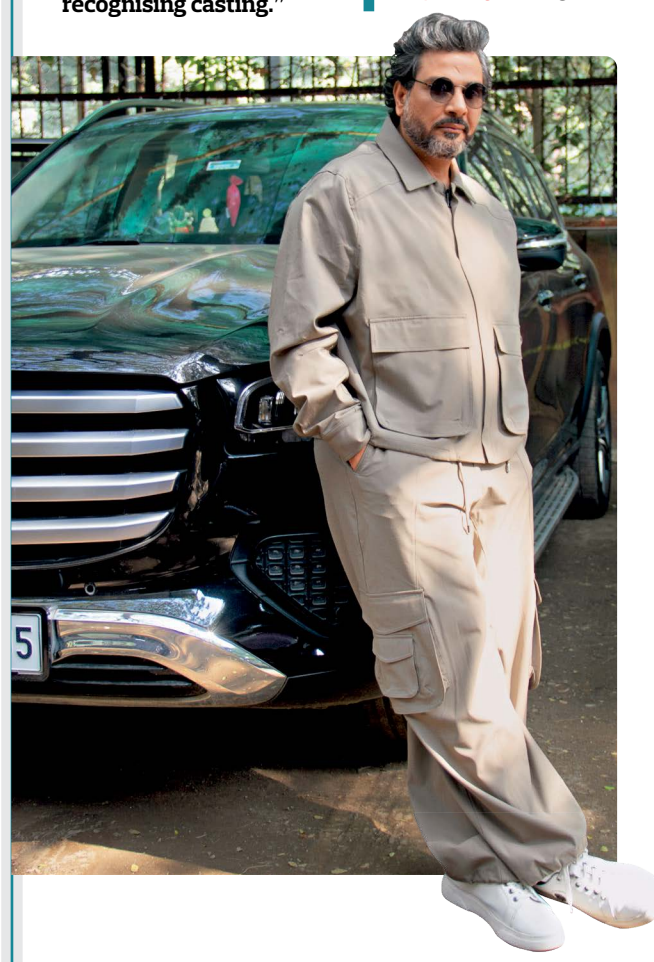
Dhurandhar is only the latest jewel in Bollywood's go-to casting director **MUKESH CHHABRA**'s crown

This year, the Oscars finally acknowledged the creators who for long have deserved recognition—casting directors. "It took them nearly 98 years to do so," says Mukesh Chhabra, the busiest casting director in Mumbai. In India, neither the National, Filmfare nor Screen awards currently recognise casting directors. Could Chhabra, with the sway he holds, get a category introduced and get his brethren the accolades they deserve? "The realisation will happen gradually," he says. "Some award shows have already started recognising casting."

It's been two decades in the field for Chhabra. Starting from a small room with two people, he now has seven offices and nearly 115 employees at the Mukesh Chhabra Casting Company. In this period, he has seen the attitude towards casting change. "I worked in so many films where casting has been appreciated, but directors didn't acknowledge it," he says. Now, there's greater weight and budget attached to finding the right talent. Chhabra, with his impressive credits—*Dangal*, *Gangs of Wasseypur*, *PK*, *Delhi Crime*, *The Family Man*, *Scam*, *Bajrangi Bhaijaan* and recently *Dhurandhar*—has proven he is adept at his job. It's why he's the trusted professional for everyone, from Rajkumar Hirani to Aditya Dhar.

Chhabra feels the weight of his job. Every day, hundreds queue outside his offices to ace an audition or catch the eye of one of his assistants. "I feel sad because so many people come with big dreams, and we have limited work to offer," he says.

> STARTING FROM A SMALL ROOM WITH JUST TWO PEOPLE, **MUKESH CHHABRA HAS NEARLY** 115 EMPLOYEES TODAY



For *Dhurandhar*, the shiniest jewel in his crown, he and his team devoted over a year and a half to cast more than 400 parts. Akshaye Khanna's part was turned down by two actors, while Rakesh Bedi's part also drew many nays. "Actors take decisions based on their judgement rather than taking advice from people around them. I feel all the actors from the 1990s don't calculate," he says, praising the likes of Sanjay Dutt, R. Madhavan and Khanna. Chhabra has words of advice for the "over-calculating new generation". "They have hired people to think for them and tell them how a role is," he says. "It's your gut feeling that will tell you." ■

—Suhani Singh